

— GROWTH CARTOGRAPHY • FIELD GUIDE 001

A \$1.3 trillion industry. 2.5 seconds of attention.

Introducing The CMO's Field Guide to System & Cohort Dynamics —
a map of the machine that now decides who sees you, and what it
costs when it stops looking.

— THE PARADOX FUNDING MODERN MARKETING

\$1.3T

what the world will spend on
advertising in 2026

2.5s

active attention the average digital
ad actually earns

— PART ONE

The signal flood

Why reach stopped working — and why
buying more of it makes the problem worse.

01

— DAILY AD EXPOSURE, THEN AND NOW

~500

ads a day in the 1970s

10,000

ads a day now — exposure grew
20×; human attention did not

— THE FLOOD HAS A SECOND-ORDER EFFECT

Disillusionomics

/ dɪs·ɪˌluːʒənˈɒm·ɪks / noun

When the machinery of persuasion becomes visible, consumers **price it in**. Every tactic they can see is a tactic they discount — and baseline trust in marketing resets lower.

— COMPOUNDING COHORT DECAY EATS UNBALANCED BUDGETS

44%

of companies focus mainly on acquisition

16%

focus mainly on retention — while every acquired cohort starts decaying on day one

— RECALIBRATE THE INSTRUMENT

The old map vs the new terrain

THE OLD MAP

Campaigns that end

Reach and impressions

Last-click credit

Microscopic targeting

A rebrand per trend

THE NEW TERRAIN

→ Cohorts that compound — or decay

→ Active attention, measured in seconds

→ Shapley-value attribution

→ Market thickness

→ One persistent identity

— PART TWO

The turn

If attention is scarce and trust is discounted,
what's left to build on?

02

“

Identity has thus become **the ultimate infrastructure** — not identity in the narrow sense of brand guidelines and logo placement, but a persistent, coherent, recognizable self that people can form a durable relationship with across channels, contexts, and time. Because belief lives in culture and trust lives in experience, persistent identity is **the connective tissue** required to bridge the two.

— HUMANS HAVE ORGANIZED AROUND SHARED BELIEF FOR ~70,000 YEARS*

The platforms changed. The physics didn't.

BELIEF

lives in culture

People adopt what their cohort already believes.
No ad unit outruns the group.

TRUST

lives in experience

Every touchpoint — chatbot to checkout —
either compounds trust or spends it.

IDENTITY

bridges the two

One persistent, recognizable self is the
only asset that works on both sides.

— THE CMO ACTION PLAN

Six imperatives for 2026

01

Rebalance toward retention

Acquisition-only budgets refill a leaking map. Fund structural retention before the cohort is gone.

02

Adopt Shapley-value attribution

Last-click is structurally gameable. Credit the whole journey with game-theoretic attribution.

03

Set rational constraints

Impossible ROAS targets don't push algorithms harder — they trigger clipping and throttle delivery.

04

Make AI use visibly ethical

Transparency is now brand equity. Private, provable data handling beats clever targeting.

05

Preserve market thickness

Hyper-granular targeting collapses reach and distorts price floors. Target culture, not microdots.

06

Treat identity as infrastructure

No reactive pivots. One coherent self across every touchpoint, platform, and year.

— EVERY FIGURE, ONE PLACE TO CHECK

Sources & methodology

01 WARC — Global Ad Forecasts, Dec 2025

\$1.3 trillion global ad spend in 2026

warc.com ↗

02 Dentsu — The Attention Economy

~2.5 seconds of active attention per digital ad

dentsu.com ↗

03 Lumen Research — Eye-Tracking Benchmarks

Attention measured, not modelled — display range ~1.5–2.5s

lumen-research.com ↗

04 CBS News / Yankelovich — Cutting Through Advertising Clutter

~500 ads a day in the 1970s, rising toward 10,000 today

cbsnews.com ↗

05 Fortune, Jan 2026 — Disillusionomics (Alice Lassman)

The term for consumers pricing in visible persuasion

fortune.com ↗

06 Econsultancy — Cross-Channel Marketing Report

44% focus on acquisition vs 16% on retention

econsultancy.com ↗



Read the full field guide.

System & Cohort Dynamics: the complete map of the machine
deciding who sees you — from compounding decay to non-
clairvoyant mechanism design.

False Dawn Industries • Growth Cartography

BUILT ON THE FDI SLIDE SYSTEM

TITLE

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